

Word family: **rather**

Base word: rather

Part of speech: adverb (副詞)

Your sentence:

> “Thanks to him, I now try to think before I react, and I would **rather** do something properly than do it quickly and badly.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **rather** appears in the pattern:

> **would rather A than B**

It means **prefer to do A instead of B**.

繁體中文： **寧願做 A，也不願做 B；比較想選擇 A 而不是 B**

中文翻譯：

> “...I would **rather** do something properly than do it quickly and badly.”

「.....而且我**寧願**把事情做好，也不願意貪快而做得很差。」

Here:

would rather do A than do B = 寧願做 A，而不做 B

1. **would rather = prefer (偏好) — 寧願；寧可**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: Used to say that you prefer one action, choice, or situation to another.

Practice 1 — Original

> “I would **rather** do something properly than do it quickly and badly.”

「我**寧願**把事情做好，也不願意貪快而做得很差。」

Practice 2

> “I’d **rather** stay home tonight.”

「我今晚**寧願**留在家。」

Practice 3

> “She would **rather** walk than wait for the bus.”

「她**寧願**走路，也不願等巴士。」

would rather + base verb = 比起另一個選擇，更願意做某件事

Common patterns:

- * would rather stay
- * would rather wait
- * would rather A than B
- * would rather not

2. **rather = quite / fairly / somewhat (程度) — 相當；頗；有點**

Rather can modify adjectives, adverbs, or certain verbs to mean **to a noticeable degree**.

Practice 4

> “The test was **rather** difficult.”

「這次測驗**頗 / 相當**困難。」

Practice 5

> “He spoke **rather** slowly.”

「他說話說得**相當慢**。」

rather = 程度比一般或預期更明顯；相當、頗、有點

The exact strength depends on context and variety of English.

3. **rather = unexpectedly / more than expected (帶驚訝語氣) — 竟然頗；出乎意料地相當**

Sometimes **rather** carries a nuance of surprise or unexpected degree.

Practice 6

> “The film was **rather** good.”

「那部電影**出乎意料地不錯 / 相當好看**。」

Practice 7

> “She seemed **rather** pleased with the result.”

「她看起來對結果**相當滿意**。」

Here **rather** may imply:

> more than I expected

For strict core counting, I would merge this with Meaning 2 because it is still a **degree** use, with a pragmatic nuance of surprise.

4. **rather** = more accurately / more exactly (修正說法) — 更確切地說；其實應該說

Rather can be used to correct or refine what has just been said.

Practice 8

> “He was tired—or **rather**, completely exhausted.”

「他很累——**更確切地說**，是完全筋疲力盡。」

Practice 9

> “It happened in May, or **rather**, at the end of April.”

「事情發生在五月——**更準確地說**，是在四月底。」

or rather = 更確切地說；用來修正或精確化前面的說法

This is a genuinely distinct discourse-function use.

5. **rather than** = instead of (取代 / 對比) — 而不是；而非

****Rather than**** introduces an alternative that is not chosen or not true.

Practice 10

> “We walked ****rather than**** took a taxi.”

More natural:

> “We walked ****rather than taking**** a taxi.”

「我們選擇走路，****而不是****乘的士。」

Practice 11

> “The problem is emotional ****rather than**** physical.”

「這個問題是情緒上的，****而不是****身體上的。」

****rather than = 而不是；表示兩者之間的對比或取代關係****

This is closely related to the preference meaning but is broader because it can contrast:

- * actions
- * nouns
- * adjectives
- * descriptions

not only personal preferences.

6. ****rather = on the contrary / instead (較正式) — 反而；相反地****

In formal or argumentative English, ****rather**** can introduce a correction or contrasting statement.

Practice 12

> “The change did not simplify the process. ****Rather****, it made it more complicated.”

「這項改變沒有令程序更簡單；****反而****令它更複雜。」

Practice 13

> “He was not angry. ****Rather****, he seemed disappointed.”

「他並不是生氣；****反而 / 更準確地說****，他看起來很失望。」

****rather** = 用來否定前一種理解，並提出更準確或相反的說法******

This overlaps with Meaning 4, but is useful to show because it often begins a new clause or sentence.

7. ****rather a/an + noun (英式 / 正式) — 頗為 ; 相當一個.....****

A distinctive construction is:

> ****rather a/an + adjective + noun****

Practice 14

> “It was ****rather a strange experience****.”

「那是一次****相當奇怪的經歷****。」

Practice 15

> “That was ****rather a difficult question****.”

「那是一條****頗難的問題****。」

This differs structurally from ordinary degree adverbs because ****rather**** comes before the article:

> rather a difficult problem

not:

> a rather difficult problem

Both can occur, but the first often sounds more emphatic or British.

8. ****would rather someone did something (希望別人.....) — 寧願 / 希望某人.....****

This is an important grammatical pattern.

Practice 16

> “I’d ****rather you waited**** outside.”

「我**寧願 / 希望你**在外面等。」

Practice 17

> “She’d **rather he didn’t mention** it.”

「她**寧願他不要提**那件事。」

Pattern:

> **would rather + subject + past tense**

This refers to a present or future preference about another person's action.

The past form here does **not** necessarily refer to past time.

This is highly useful learner grammar.

Important distinction: **rather vs quite**

Both can indicate degree.

rather

often means:

- * fairly / quite
- * sometimes more than expected
- * sometimes slightly negative or surprising

quite

can vary more widely by context and dialect.

> “rather difficult”

= 相當困難

> “quite difficult”

can also mean 相當困難

But they are not always identical in tone.

Important distinction: **rather** vs **fairly**

fairly

often sounds neutral or moderate:

> “fairly good”

= 還不錯 / 頗好

rather

can sound stronger or more marked:

> “rather good”

= 相當好，有時帶點出乎意料

So **rather** can carry more speaker attitude.

Important distinction: **rather** vs **prefer**

prefer

is a normal lexical verb:

> “I prefer tea.”

would rather

is a modal-like preference construction:

> “I’d rather drink tea.”

Patterns differ:

> prefer A to B

> would rather A than B

So:

> “I prefer walking to driving.”

> “I’d rather walk than drive.”

Both express preference.

Important distinction: **rather than** vs **instead of**

These often overlap.

instead of

usually introduces an alternative noun or -ing form:

> “Instead of driving, we walked.”

rather than

is structurally more flexible:

> “We walked rather than drove.”

> “It was practical rather than elegant.”

So **rather than** often works especially well for direct contrast between parallel items.

Important distinction: **rather** vs **rather than**

rather

alone can mean:

- * quite
- * preferably
- * more accurately

rather than

means:

- * instead of
- * and not

So they should not be treated as the same construction despite sharing the word.

Family-extension note

Rather has almost no productive morphological family.

The real learning burden lies in its grammatical patterns:

- * would rather
- * would rather A than B
- * would rather someone did...
- * rather + adjective/adverb
- * rather a/an + noun
- * rather than
- * or rather
- * rather, + clause

This is exactly the kind of grammar-rich word where the family itself is small but the functional range is broad. The Golden Manual explicitly allows separate grammatical functions where they create genuinely different learner meanings or constructions.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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would rather	比起另一個選擇，更願意 / 寧願做某件事
rather — degree	表示某種特質或程度相當明顯；相當、頗、有點
rather — unexpected degree	表示程度比預期更高，常帶輕微驚訝；屬於 degree 義
or rather	修正或精確化剛才的說法；更確切地說
rather than	引出被排除或取代的選項；而不是 / 而非
rather — contrastive discourse marker	否定前一說法並提出更準確或相反的內容；反而 / 相反地
would rather someone did... 	表示希望另一個人現在或將來採取某種行動

For your original sentence

> "...I would **rather** do something properly than do it quickly and badly."

The exact pattern is:

> **would rather A than B**

The exact meaning is:

****比起 B , 更願意選擇 A****

So:

> ****I would rather do it properly than do it quickly and badly.****

= ****我寧願把它做好做妥 , 也不願為了快而草草完成。 ****

This directly reflects the grandfather's lesson:

> quality and patience > speed and carelessness

For your database, I would count ****4 genuinely useful core functions**** for ****rather****:

1. ****would rather — express preference****
2. ****degree adverb — quite / fairly / somewhat****
3. ****rather than — instead of / contrasted with****
4. ****corrective/discourse use — or rather / rather, ...****

I would keep ****would rather someone did... **** under #1 as an important grammar pattern, and merge the surprise nuance of ****rather good / rather difficult**** into #2 rather than inflate the count.